day and capturing two alive. Akbar then found out about the pilgrimage tax imposed upon Hindus visiting the temples, a tax which brought in millions of rupees to the royal exchequer every year. Akbar abolished this tax throughout the empire saying ‘however obvious the error of some people is’, referring to Hindu beliefs, ‘since the error of their ways is not obvious to them, to demand anything from them and to place a stumbling block in their path to whatever leads them to the threshold of divine unity and the worship of God are less than praiseworthy to the wise, since it will necessarily lead to divine disfavour’. Farmans were issued forbidding the practice and each time a new region was integrated into the Mughal Empire, the farman would be reissued.

It is not surprising that Akbar, visiting Mathura, would have been struck by the devotion of the visiting pilgrims. Mathura attracted swarming numbers of pilgrims to its temples on the banks of the Yamuna, where more than 300 barbers stood in waist-deep water on the steps leading into the river. There they would swiftly shave the hair off the bowed heads of pilgrims, both men and women, who would then sink into the warm water of the river before emerging, cleansed and bald, to present themselves for blessings at the temple.

And, indeed, the temples of Mathura would become an important focus of imperial attention. In a few years, Akbar would issue a farman granting 200 bighas of land as a revenue-free gift to the Govind Dev temple. Many more such gifts would follow, including from his Hindu courtiers and from his mother, Hamida Banu. It is quite likely that a new sensitivity was also stoked by Akbar’s Rajput bride, Harkha Bai. The Kachhwahas were Vaishnavas from the time of Prithviraj Kachhwaha and their particular deities were Shri Sitaramji and Govind Devji. Bhagwant Das and later Man Singh would lavishly patronize temples at Mathura which was, along with Brindavan at that time, the vortex of the high-voltage passion of the Bhakti movement.

Akbar, on this occasion after the lion hunt, decided to walk back from Mathura to Agra in one day, a distance of some 60 kilometres. His enthusiastic companions all set off with their Padshah but only three, it was said, kept up with his blistering speed and were able to reach Agra the same day. Were these repeated tests of strength and endurance just youthful exuberance, or was there a deeper disquiet, an intolerable questioning of purpose and meaning? ‘On the completion of my twentieth year,’ Akbar